

Ramayan: Chapter on Rama's Exile (Vanavasa)

On the eve of his coronation, Prince Rama of Ayodhya was loved by all for his virtue, discipline, and compassion. The city was decorated in joy, and the people waited eagerly for their ideal king. But within the palace, Queen Kaikeyi, influenced by fear and ambition, demanded two boons once promised by King Dasharatha: Rama's exile for fourteen years and Bharata's coronation.

Bound by honor, Dasharatha could not refuse. Rama accepted the decree without anger, seeing duty to father and truth as greater than personal gain. Sita insisted on joining him, saying that a wife shares both fortune and hardship. Lakshmana too accompanied them, devoted to service and protection.

The people of Ayodhya wept as the trio departed for the forest. Rama consoled them, teaching that righteousness must be upheld even when it is painful. In exile he lived among sages, defended hermitages, and upheld justice far from the comforts of the court.

This chapter reveals the moral center of the Ramayan: true kingship begins with self-mastery, sacrifice, and unwavering commitment to dharma. Rama lost a throne for a time, but gained eternal reverence as the embodiment of righteous conduct.